



Volunteer
Home Buyers

Free Homeowner Guide

A KNOX COUNTY HOMEOWNER'S GUIDE

Facing foreclosure? You still have options.

A free, no-pressure guide to protecting your home, your credit, and your family's next step — written by three neighbors who grew up right here in Knoxville.



YOU HAVE OPTIONS

Keep your home, sell on your terms, or work things out with your bank. We'll help you understand every path — and choose the one that's right for you.

CALL OR TEXT ANYTIME

(865) 324-1736



Locally owned
Born & raised in Knoxville

START HERE

You are not alone — and you have time.

If you're reading this, you may be facing one of the most stressful moments a homeowner can go through. Take a breath. Foreclosure is rarely as fast or as final as it feels, and at every stage there is something you can do. This guide walks you through every option in plain language — no jargon, no pressure.

Our only goal for this guide

That you finish it knowing exactly what your choices are — whether that means keeping your home, selling it on your terms, or working something out with your bank. Even if you never call us, we want you to feel back in control.

WHAT'S INSIDE

03 Meet your neighbors**05** The Knox County timeline**07** Option 2 — Sell & move forward**09** Myths vs. reality**11** Questions homeowners ask**13** How working with us works**17** Free local resources**04** What foreclosure really means**06** Option 1 — Keep your home**08** Option 3 — Negotiate with your bank**10** Your rights in Tennessee**12** Three ways we can help**14** Families we've helped**18** Your next three steps

MEET YOUR NEIGHBORS

We're Reid, Ty & Mark.



OWNERS · VOLUNTEER HOME BUYERS

We've been best friends since we were kids growing up in Knoxville. This city raised us — our families, our schools, our first jobs, all of it. We started Volunteer Home Buyers because we kept watching neighbors lose their homes without ever knowing they had other options. That didn't sit right with us.

So we built something simple: when you call our number, you talk directly to one of us — not a call center, not a salesperson. Just three guys from Knoxville who want to help you find the best next step, whether that's keeping your home, selling it, or working something out with your bank.

 No pressure

 No judgment

 Just honest help

Talk to us directly. One of us will actually pick up.

(865) 324-1736

CHAPTER 01

What foreclosure really means

In plain terms: if you fall behind on your mortgage, your lender can eventually sell your home to recover what's owed. But “eventually” is the key word — there are stops along the way, and each one is a chance to act.

KEY FACTS ABOUT FORECLOSURE IN TENNESSEE



Tennessee is a non-judicial state

Most foreclosures here don't need a court order, so the process can move faster than in other states. Knowing that is exactly why acting early matters.



You usually have months, not days

Federal rules generally stop a lender from starting foreclosure until you're more than 120 days behind — so you typically have several months to act.



You can usually reinstate

In most cases you can stop foreclosure by bringing your loan current — paying what's past due plus fees — any time before the sale.



The credit hit is real, but avoidable

A foreclosure can stay on your credit up to 7 years and drop your score by roughly 100–150 points. Other options protect your credit far more.

The most important thing to remember

Foreclosure is **not** inevitable. At every stage — even a late one — you have options, and we're here to help you explore them.

CHAPTER 02

The Knox County foreclosure timeline

How it typically unfolds — and where you can still step in. Timelines vary, but the pattern is consistent.

DAY 1

Missed payment

Your lender reaches out. At this stage the issue can often be resolved with a single payment or a quick phone call.

30–90 DAYS BEHIND

Falling behind

Late fees add up and your servicer sends notices. You still have real room to act — this is the ideal time to explore your options.

120+ DAYS BEHIND

Demand & referral

Usually only now can the lender accelerate the loan and start foreclosure, proceeding through the trustee named in your deed of trust.

BEFORE THE SALE

Notice of sale published

The sale is advertised in a Knox County newspaper for three consecutive weeks, and a date is set. Options may still be available.

SALE DAY

Trustee's auction

The home is sold to the highest bidder on the steps of the City-County Building on Main Street. Until then, you can still step in.



THE EARLIER YOU ACT, THE MORE YOU KEEP

Even after a sale notice is published, options like reinstatement, a short sale, or a cash sale may still be on the table. Not sure where you fall on this timeline? Call or text **(865) 324-1736** and we'll help you place it.

OPTION 01

Keep your home

Ways to get back on track and stay right where you are.

01

If keeping your home is the goal, several proven paths can get you back on track. The key is acting quickly — the sooner you explore these, the better your chances.

01

Reinstatement

Pay everything past due, plus fees, in one lump sum. It immediately stops the process and brings your mortgage current.

Best if you've come into money — a tax refund, insurance payout, or family help.

02

Repayment plan

Your lender spreads the past-due balance across your future payments for a set time until you're caught up.

Best if you're back on your feet and can handle a slightly higher payment for a while.

03

Forbearance

Your lender pauses or lowers payments for a set period — usually 3–6 months — then you make up the difference.

Best if you're facing a temporary hardship, like a job loss or medical issue.

04

Loan modification

Your lender permanently changes your terms: a lower rate, longer term, or reduced balance. Many prefer this over foreclosure.

Best if you can afford a lower payment, just not your current one.

Not sure which one fits? We'll help you figure it out — free.

(865) 324-1736

OPTION 02

Sell & move forward

Sell on your terms — before the bank decides for you.

02

Sometimes the best move is to sell and start fresh. Done before a foreclosure, a sale protects your credit, puts cash in your pocket, and lets **you** control the timeline — not the bank.

TRADITIONAL SALE

The slow road

- ✗ List with a real estate agent
- ✗ Repairs & staging first
- ✗ 60–90+ days to close
- ✗ ~6% in agent commissions
- ✗ Buyer financing can fall through
- ✗ Inspections & appraisals
- ✗ Works only if you have time

CASH SALE TO US

The fast, certain road

- ✓ No agents, no commissions
- ✓ Sell as-is — no repairs needed
- ✓ Close in as little as 14 days
- ✓ Zero fees or closing costs
- ✓ Guaranteed close, no fall-through
- ✓ No inspections required
- ✓ Ideal when time is short

WHY SELLING BEFORE FORECLOSURE MAKES SENSE



Protect your credit

Far gentler than foreclosure — you could buy again in about 2 years, not 7.



Control the timeline

You choose the closing date. No sheriff's sale, no auction, no surprises.



Walk away with cash

Depending on your equity, you can leave closing with money to start fresh.



Keep it private

A foreclosure is public record. A private sale keeps your business your business.

OPTION 03

Negotiate with your bank

Work out a deal directly with your lender.

03

You may have more leverage than you think. Banks lose an average of **\$50,000 or more** on a foreclosure, so they're often willing to work something out. Here are the most common paths.



Short sale

If you owe more than the home is worth, the bank agrees to let you sell for less than the balance and forgives the difference — far less damaging to your credit than foreclosure.

How we help → We handle the whole short-sale process for you — paperwork, bank negotiations, and closing.



Deed in lieu of foreclosure

You voluntarily hand the deed back to the bank, and in exchange it releases you from the mortgage — avoiding the formal foreclosure entirely.

How we help → We can help you negotiate terms that protect your interests.



Bankruptcy protection

Filing Chapter 13 triggers an “automatic stay” that immediately halts foreclosure and lets you reorganize debts over 3–5 years.

How we help → We can connect you with a trusted Knox County bankruptcy attorney for a free consultation.



AN HONEST NOTE

We're not attorneys, and this guide isn't legal advice. But we work with trusted Knox County professionals who can guide you through the legal side of any of these paths.

MYTH VS. REALITY

Five things homeowners get wrong

Fear fills in the blanks with worst-case stories. Here's what's actually true.

Myth "The bank wants to take my house."

Reality Banks lose money on foreclosures — often \$50,000+ per home. They'd much rather work out a deal. It's their last resort, not their first move.

Myth "If I ignore it, it might sort itself out."

Reality This is the costliest myth of all. Foreclosure doesn't pause on its own — every day you wait removes options. The best thing you can do is act today.

Myth "I've already missed payments, so it's too late."

Reality It's almost never too late. Even after a sale notice is published, reinstatement, a short sale, or a cash sale can still be on the table.

Myth "I'll never be able to buy a home again."

Reality With a foreclosure you may wait around 7 years. But after a voluntary sale or short sale, you could qualify for a new mortgage in as little as 2–3 years.

Myth "I need to hire an expensive attorney."

Reality Legal advice is valuable, but many paths — like selling or arranging a forbearance — don't require an attorney. We help homeowners navigate these at no cost.

KNOW YOUR RIGHTS

Your rights as a Tennessee homeowner

Tennessee law and your loan documents give you real protections. Understanding them is the first step to using them.



Right to reinstate

Most Tennessee mortgages let you bring the loan current before the sale by paying past-due amounts plus fees. It comes from your loan contract, so confirm your specific terms.



Right to surplus funds

If your home sells at auction for more than you owe, the extra money belongs to you. Don't leave it on the table.



Right to challenge

If the lender didn't follow proper procedure — like improper notice — you may be able to challenge the foreclosure in court.



Right to notice

Your loan documents and federal servicing rules generally require written notice before a sale — including its date, time, and place.



Right to occupy until sale

You can stay in your home until the foreclosure sale is complete. No one can force you out before that date.



Servicemembers Civil Relief Act

If you or your spouse are active-duty military, the SCRA adds protections, including a cap on mortgage interest and foreclosure safeguards.

PLEASE NOTE

This is general information, not legal advice. For your specific situation, talk with a qualified Tennessee attorney — we're glad to point you to one.

STRAIGHT ANSWERS

Questions homeowners ask us

The real questions we hear every week — answered plainly.

Q How quickly can you buy my house?

In as little as 14 days — or on your timeline. You pick the closing date.

Q What condition does it need to be in?

Any condition. We buy as-is — no cleaning, no staging. Leave what you don't want and we'll handle it.

Q Is there really no cost to me?

Correct — zero fees, commissions, or closing costs. We make our money when we renovate and resell, not by charging you.

Q Can you help after a Notice of Sale?

Yes. Even at this late stage you have options, and a cash sale can close faster than the foreclosure. Call us right away.

Q Are you really buying, or selling my contract?

We buy directly with our own funds — no middlemen, no last-minute fall-throughs. When we make an offer, we have the capital to close it ourselves.

Q Will I owe anything after the sale?

In most cases, no. We cover closing costs, and if you owe more than the home is worth, we can help negotiate a short sale.

Q Will this hurt my credit?

Selling before foreclosure is far easier on your credit than letting the foreclosure go through.

Q What if I'm behind on property taxes too?

We handle that. Back taxes, liens, code violations — we take care of them at closing so you walk away clean.

Q What if I just need time to think?

That's exactly what this guide is for. No pressure — read through your options and reach out when you're ready.

— HOW WE HELP

Three ways we can help you today

No matter where you are in the process, there's a way forward. Notice which one comes first — that's on purpose.

01



Help you keep your home

We'll review your situation and connect you with the right resources — a loan-modification specialist, housing counselor, or attorney. If keeping your home is possible, we'll help you find the path.

02



Buy your home & help you move

If selling makes the most sense, we'll make a fair cash offer within 24 hours. No repairs, no commissions. Pick your closing date and walk away with cash in hand.

03



Negotiate with your bank

If you owe more than the home is worth, we'll negotiate a short sale on your behalf — the paperwork, the calls, all of it. You focus on your next chapter.

Ready to talk? Or just want a **free, no-obligation offer** to compare?

(865) 324-1736

Or visit volunteerhomebuyers.com anytime.

— OUR PROCESS

How working with us works

Four simple steps, at your pace. You're in control the whole way through.

1

Reach out

Call or text (865) 324-1736, or fill out the form at volunteerhomebuyers.com. Tell us what's going on — it's confidential.

Takes about 5 minutes

2

We talk through your options

In person or by phone, we'll walk through every path — keeping your home, selling, or negotiating — and what each means for you.

Usually within 24 hours

3

You choose your path

You decide what's right. If selling makes sense, we present a fair cash offer. If keeping your home is possible, we connect you with the right help.

No obligation, no pressure

4

We handle the details

Once you decide, we take care of the paperwork, the lender coordination, and closing logistics. You focus on your family.

Close on your timeline

You never owe us anything to talk

There's no cost and no catch to step one. Most people just want to understand their options — and that conversation is always free.

OUR TRACK RECORD

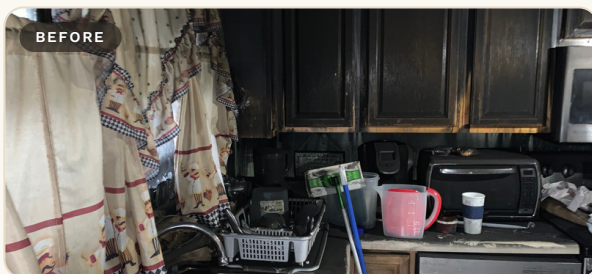
Real families, right here in Knox County

Names are changed for privacy — the situations are real. Every family's path was different: some we helped sell, others we simply pointed toward the right counselor or attorney.

Buffat Mill Road

Fire damage & falling behind

SOLD AS-IS



BEFORE



AFTER

The situation

A house fire left the home unlivable. Between the insurance process and mortgage payments on a home they couldn't occupy, the owners fell further behind every month and were facing foreclosure.

What we did

We bought the property as-is while the insurance claim was still open — a complicated situation, but one we worked through together.

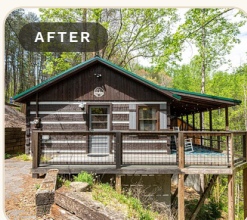
✓ Home purchased as-is · insurance settled · family moved into a fresh start.

OUR TRACK RECORD · CONTINUED

Ridgecrest Drive

Loss, illness & an out-of-state owner

PRE-FORECLOSURE RESOLVED



The situation

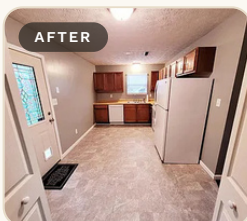
The owner had lost his wife and was living out of state while his son fought cancer. The Knox County home slipped into pre-foreclosure with years of deferred maintenance piling up.

✓ Pre-foreclosure resolved · burden lifted · family free to focus on what mattered most.

Joan Drive

An inherited home too far gone to renovate

TAX FORECLOSURE STOPPED



The situation

A family inherited the home meaning to renovate it themselves — until they saw the scope. It sat vacant, fell behind on taxes, and was heading toward a tax sale.

✓ Tax foreclosure stopped · vacant home sold · family received their full inheritance.

OUR TRACK RECORD · CONTINUED

Willoway Circle

A hoarding situation & HOA foreclosure

SOLD WITH CONTENTS



The situation

Inherited by a sibling facing a severe hoarding situation, the home was packed floor to ceiling and unlivable. The HOA had begun foreclosure and the taxes were past due.

What we did

We took it exactly as-is — every item, the HOA issues, the back taxes. The seller didn't clean out a thing, and we cleared every lien at closing.

✓ HOA foreclosure stopped · taxes cleared · purchased as-is, contents and all.

What these families had in common

Every one of them believed they were out of options. None of them were. Whatever your situation looks like, there is very likely a path forward — and a single call is the way to find it.

FREE LOCAL HELP

Knox County resources

Free and low-cost help available to you right now — whether or not you ever call us.



HUD-approved housing counseling

Free, government-backed counseling to help you understand your options.

hud.gov · (800) 569-4287



Legal Aid of East Tennessee

Free legal help for qualifying homeowners facing foreclosure.

(865) 637-0484 for intake



Tennessee Housing Development Agency

Homeowner assistance and hardest-hit-fund programs.

thda.org · (615) 815-2200



Knox County Trustee

For property taxes, tax liens, and payment plans.

400 Main St, Suite 427 · (865) 215-2305



Knox County Register of Deeds

To check liens, deeds, and the status of your property records.

400 Main St, Suite 225 · (865) 215-2330



211 Tennessee

Emergency housing, utility help, and financial counseling.

Dial 2-1-1

Resource details are current as of 2026 — please verify before visiting or calling.

— WHERE TO START

Your next three steps

You don't have to solve everything today. You just have to start. Here's how.

1

Take a breath

You have more time and more options than it feels like right now. Nothing happens today that you can't get ahead of.

2

Gather your papers

Find your mortgage statement, any letters from your lender, and a rough sense of what you owe. It makes the next conversation easy.

3

Make one call

Call or text us, a HUD counselor, or an attorney. One conversation is usually all it takes to see the path forward.

You don't have to have it figured out

That's our job. Call or text **(865) 324-1736** and we'll help you find the right next step — even if that step isn't us. No pressure, no judgment, ever.

YOU HAVE OPTIONS

Let us help you find the right one.

Whether you want to keep your home, sell it, or negotiate with your bank — we're here for you. Every conversation is free and completely confidential.

CALL OR TEXT ANYTIME

(865) 324-1736



volunteerhomebuyers.com



Volunteer Home
Buyers



REID · TY · MARK

You have
options.
Let us help.

Whether you want to keep your home, sell it, or negotiate with your bank
— every conversation is free and confidential.

📞 (865) 324-1736

volunteerhomebuyers.com

LOCALLY OWNED · BORN & RAISED IN KNOXVILLE

Volunteer Homebuyer Group LLC · This guide is informational and is not legal or financial advice.